

A blight on sport

There should be some way of **restoring justice** to sports so badly abused by a structure — government-sponsored doping — which placed the system above the individual.

Suresh Menon

The Paris Olympic Games are around the corner, and inevitably, doping is part of the conversation.

Since the fall of the Iron Curtain, two major schemes have emerged of sustained, government-sponsored doping. Access to the files of the Stasi has revealed that in 1974, East Germany passed legislation formalising — in fact insisting on — doping as a key element in the preparation of athletes.

More than ten thousand children and women were forcibly doped, making the country's achievements between 1976 and 1988 dubious. The tiny nation finished second in the medals tally in 1976, '80 and '88 (they boycotted the Olympics in 1984).

It is now accepted that the Moscow Olympics in 1980 was a triumph of chemists over athletes; testing wasn't sophisticated enough. Overall Russia has been stripped of 48 medals at the Olympics, more than any other country, and was banned for fiddling with the drug tests. There too, both in the days of the Soviet Union and later, there has been systematic state-sponsored doping.

But can the East Germans who won at those Games (and the Winter Olympics too — a total of 489 medals) be stripped of their medals? "East Germany never positioned worse than second on an Olympic medal table in either the sun or snow," wrote the Australian columnist Darren Kane, pointing out the legal difficulties involved.

Firstly, no East German failed a dope test at the Olympics. There was no ruling on what drugs were and when and how they might not be taken. We cannot



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assume that every athlete from East Germany won because of doping — that's tough to prove. The WADA code says that all cases must be brought against the athletes within a decade of the date the violations allegedly occurred.

More interestingly, the East Germans didn't break any rules. Officially, drug testing began at the Mexico Olympics in 1968. One athlete failed because he had had a couple of beers. Alcohol was banned, steroids weren't — and they weren't until 1976.

Can we use the rules of 2024 to retrospectively punish those who were ingesting

performance-enhancing drugs in the 1970s, but whose efficacy wasn't properly known and thus were not banned?

The cancel culture, so much a thing of today often asks the same question: what was acceptable yesterday might not be kosher today, but is that reason enough for the 'cancellation'? You can only break a law that exists, not one that will come into force years later.

What these countries did is a blight on sport. Lives were destroyed without a second thought — all in the cause of proving a political point. Yet, there should be some way of restoring justice to sports so badly abused by a structure which placed the system above the individual.

'Victims' are both those who were denied medals as well as those who were put through the drugs regimen. Some of the latter were compensated for medical consequences after the reunification.

But a few thousand dollars and 'moral' victory in a race alone don't quite cut it.